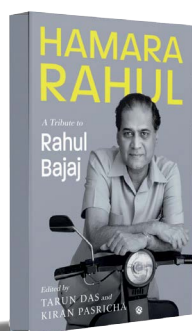


A Man of Multitudes

IN A NEW BOOK, CAPTAINS OF INDIA INC. AND OTHERS PAY TRIBUTE TO RAHUL BAJAJ, THE TITAN OF INDIAN INDUSTRY

BY ARNAV DAS SHARMA

120 |



**HAMARA RAHUL:
A TRIBUTE TO RAHUL BAJAJ**

**EDITED BY TARUN DAS,
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IN THE SPRAWLING NARRATIVE of India's economic evolution, one name stands out as a luminary with profound contributions—Rahul Bajaj. For those growing up in the 1990s, one advertisement that stood out was that of the humble Bajaj Chetak scooter, released in 1989. And added to this was the beautiful jingle that spoke of the aspirations of an India on the cusp of liberalisation. And one can say that Rahul Bajaj's imprint on India's industrial landscape is visible, perhaps most vividly, through this advertisement and the now-iconic "Hamara Bajaj" (Our Bajaj) campaign.

This marketing marvel not only transformed Bajaj Auto into a household name but also became a cultural phenomenon, symbolising aspirations, dreams, and the spirit of a burgeoning nation. That campaign struck a chord with millions, resonating with the then prevailing Indian ethos of affordability, reliability, and accessibility.

But who was Rahul Bajaj? How does one make sense of such a multifaceted life as his? That's why this book, *Hamara Rahul: A Tribute to Rahul Bajaj*, edited by Tarun Das and Kiran Pasricha, uses multiple voices, culled from across India's business fraternity, to give a glimpse into Rahul Bajaj the person.

For instance, Krishna Palepu, the Ross Graham Walker Professor of Business Administration at Harvard Business School, succinctly encapsulates Rahul Bajaj's towering presence in the corporate landscape. "Rahul's visionary leadership and strategic foresight in steering the Bajaj Group have crafted an enduring legacy that resonates with hundreds of millions across India," he writes. Under his stewardship, Bajaj Auto emerged as a trailblazer, revolutionising transportation with its iconic two-wheelers and auto-rickshaws, which, in turn, became synonymous with reliability and affordability for millions of Indians.

But Rahul Bajaj was also a champion of economic liberalisation, which opened up the world to India, after decades of the Licence-Permit Raj. This is aptly underscored by Reliance Industries Chairman Mukesh